Singh in the bypoll to the Sangrur Lok Sabha seat, which Bhagwant Mann had to relinquish after taking over as chief minister. The same month, another pro-Khalistan group took out an "Azadi March" in Amritsar to commemorate the 38th anniversary of the controversial Operation Blue Star. The march took place with police protection. Later in mid-July, the state-owned PRTC was forced to withdraw orders to remove the pictures of terrorists Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale and Jagtar Singh Hawara that had adorned some of its buses. In fact, their visage now crops up universally across the state in graffiti scrawled on the walls of government buildings and parks.

And how did Mann deal with the situation? He sent the then Director General of Police (DGP) V.K. Bhawra on leave and made Gaurav Yadav, an officer of the 1992 batch, the officiating DGP. Mann reportedly circumvented rules to hand Yadav the plum post. To appoint a regular DGP, the shortlist must have the top three available officers. And the choice has to be made in consultation with the UPSC (Union Public Service Commission). Yadav is junior to 1988 batch IPS officer Prabodh Kumar, Sanjeev Kalra (1989 batch) and his own batchmates Sharad Satya Chauhan and Harpreet Singh Sidhu. Not just that, the rules permit a state to have a non-regular DGP only for six months. That deadline ended on January 4. But neither did the Centre challenge it nor did the state make any effort to change the status quo. To this day, therefore, no full-time DGP has been appointed in Punjab and Yadav continues as the officiating chief.

What set alarm bells off, which could be heard even in Delhi, was the violence that erupted on February 23 after the pro-Khalistan propagandist Amritpal Singh Sandhu, who heads a faction of the Waris Punjab De (Inheritors of Punjab), and his followers laid siege to a police station in Ajnala town, close to the Pakistan border. They forced the police to agree to get one of their associates, Lovepreet Singh 'Toofan', who had been arrested the previous week on kidnapping charges, discharged from local court. The protesters wielded swords and lathis and Amritpal himself carried a copy of the Guru Granth Sahib on a palanquin into the police station, daring the lawmakers to strike him. Even though his followers rained blows on the police, injuring six of them, senior police officers refused to order retaliatory firing for fear of escalating the violence. What it ended up doing was make them look impotent and embolden radical outfits in the state.

An AAP source refutes such charges, saying, "As a party, we are outright nationalists and will never do anything that would remotely jeopardise national security. The Punjab police is the bravest force in the country, singularly responsible for eliminating militancy from the state. Police hands were tied because of the cowardly act of the Shri Guru Granth Sahibji being used as a shield.

The incident has already forced Giani Harpreet Singh, the Akal Takht jathedar (priest of the highest seat of the Sikhs), to constitute a sub-committee of 15 Sikh intellectuals to review the circumstances under which the holy book can be taken to protest sites. Meanwhile, Mann tweeted in Punjabi—"Those who take

RADICAL RISE

Punjab's ferment has become fertile ground for young pro-Khalistan radical Amritpal Singh to sow hatred. Why are the state's youth buying it?

Daring deed, or act of foolishness? For someone who preaches Sikhi and screams Sikh genocide every time there's an attack on something the Sikhs hold sacred, it was universally seen as an act of extreme impropriety when Amritpal Singh Sandhu used the Guru Granth Sahib as a shield while marching into the Ajnala police station to secure the release of his aide Lovepreet Singh 'Toofan'. The police stood by helplessly, because attacking him would amount to defiling the Sikh holy book. And thus Amritpal managed to get away with what most Sikhs would consider the ultimate sacrilege.



No one really knew who Amritpal was till two years back. Born in 1993 in Jallupur Khera village in Amritsar district, the man who has become something of a radical 'phenomenon' in recent months had a quiet, unassuming start—attending the Holy Heart Public School and later acquiring a mechanical engineering degree from the Lord Krishna Polytechnic College in Kapurthala. He then joined the family cargo transport business in Dubai and worked as an operations manager. In a conversation with INDIA TODAY, Amritpal said he was an average student; his understanding of religion was derived from watching scholars' sermons on YouTube and the like. A change came over Amritpal during 2020-21, when the farmers' agitation rocked Punjab. He visited India, took part in the protests, and became a follower of actor-activist Deep Sidhu, who had formed a pressure group called Waris Punjab De. Amritpal, active on Twitter, Instagram and Clubhouse, began acquiring a following by pushing his views on the agitation among other issues. Still, the well-groomed, short-haired young man went back to Dubai, seemingly content after the Centre repealed the farm laws. Then, Sidhu died in a car crash in February 2022.

Amritpal's next appearance in India, to take